

on Rome's enemies. Each consul checked the work of the other to make sure that neither became too powerful.

strong armies led by powerful generals. During the closing years of the Roman Republic, a civil war broke out between

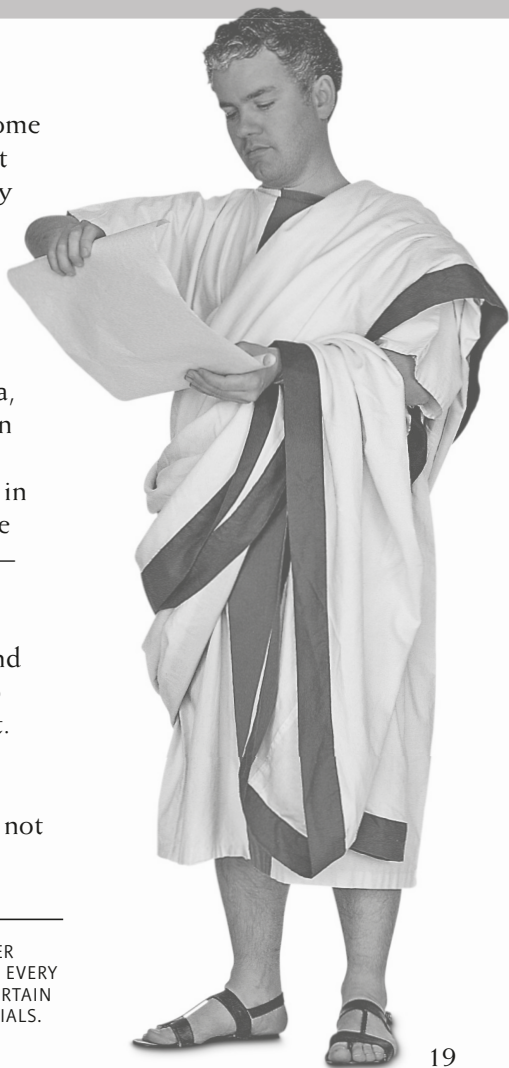
BY 120 CE, AS MANY AS 50 MILLION PEOPLE LIVED UNDER ROMAN RULE.

The rise of Rome

It was during the years of the Roman Republic that Rome developed into the strongest force in Italy. Rome gradually overpowered Italy's other city-states and brought them under its control. A long series of wars fought against Carthage, a major power based in North Africa, ended in victory for Rome in 146 BCE. This triumph left Rome as the greatest power in the Mediterranean. Over the following 100 years, Rome—backed by the might of its army—took control of vast tracts of land, from Spain and Gaul (France) in the west to Greece and Syria in the east.

Civil war!

Rome's rise to power would not have been possible without



DURING THE ROMAN REPUBLIC, POWER LAY IN THE HANDS OF THE SENATORS. EVERY YEAR, THE PEOPLE VOTED TO ELECT CERTAIN SENATORS TO BE GOVERNMENT OFFICIALS.